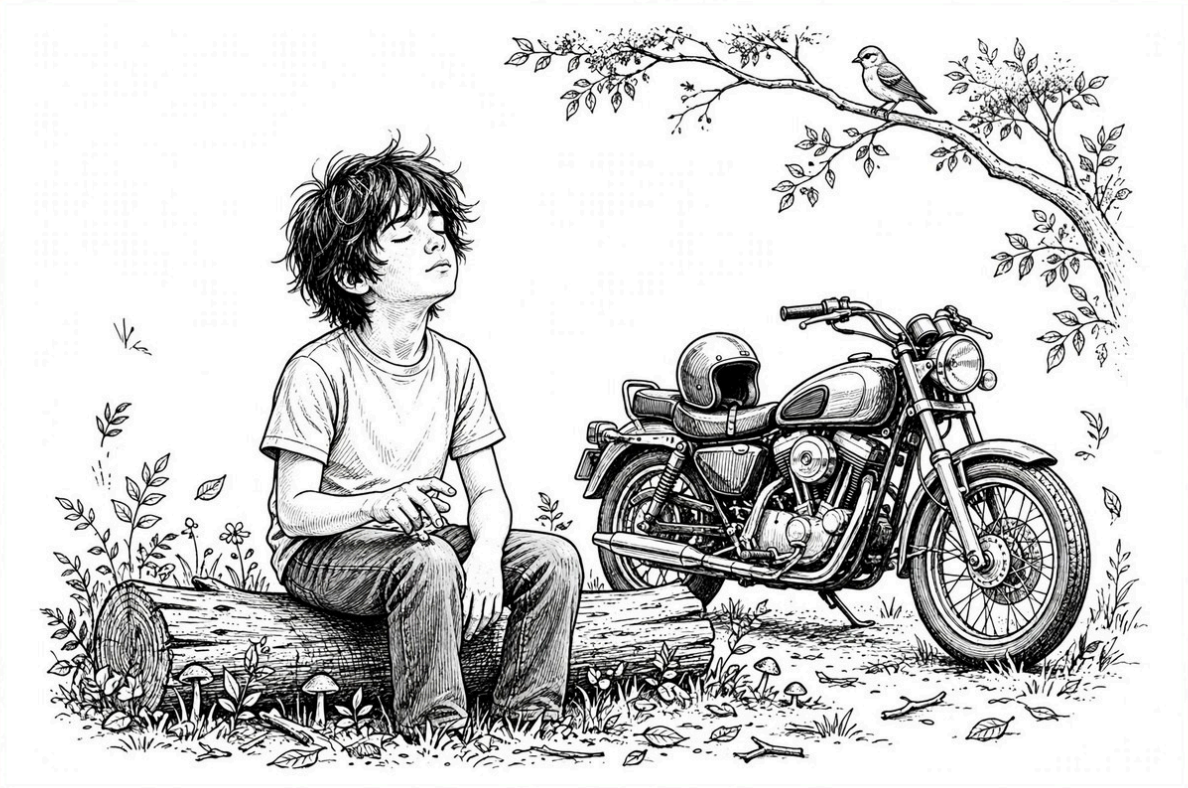
DOUG'S BOOK



A STORYBOOK ABOUT DOUG

A PERSONALIZED STORYBOOK

DOUG'S BOOK

RAMBLEBOOK

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ABOUT THIS DRAFT

Doug's Book is a working draft, produced with RambleBook from an original story idea. It is complete as a story — beginning, middle, and end, in 6 chapters — and deliberately unfinished as a book. Chapter One is written at full weight; the chapters that follow are leaner, the way first drafts are: the bones and the heartbeat, waiting for a writer's second pass. Writing is rewriting. This is the draft you rewrite from.

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Chapter 1

A Song in the Engine

Doug eased his motorcycle into the clearing and stopped beneath the trees.

He switched off the engine.

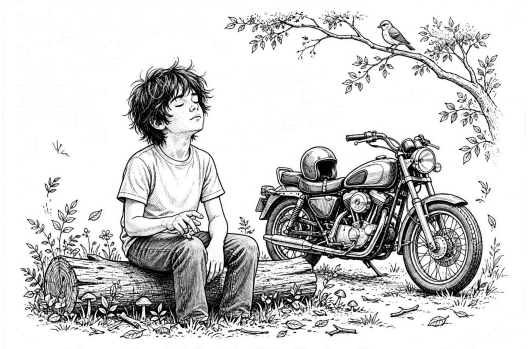
For a moment, the woods seemed quiet.

Then a bird called twice. A branch creaked. Somewhere overhead, leaves went shhhhh.

Doug tapped his gloved fingers against his knee.

Put-put. Chirp-chirp. Shhhhh.

There was a song in there.



At sixteen, Doug didn't always have much to say. But give him a sound worth listening to, and he could find something to do with it.

He loved riding motorcycles in the woods. He loved the bends in the trail, the trees opening ahead, and the engine's steady rumble. Today, he wanted to bring a little of that home.

He checked his helmet strap and started back along the trail.

Later, with the motorcycle parked and his helmet off, Doug opened the gate. His dog came bounding over.

"Find anything interesting while I was gone?"

The dog sniffed his boot.

"Right. Full inspection."

One boot. The other boot. A particularly thorough investigation of his trouser cuff.

His partner in crime took the work seriously.

Doug fetched his guitar and a sheet of paper. On the porch, he picked out a low, rolling rhythm. The dog settled beside his shoe.

Doug played two bright notes for the bird.

Then he brushed his fingers across the strings for the leaves.

The dog lifted his head.

"Too much wind?"

Doug tried it more softly.

The head went down again.

"Good note. Thank you."

He wrote a line, crossed out two words, and sang:

“The road runs out, but the day rolls on.”

That felt right.

A second line followed. Then a third.

The last line refused to come.

Doug stared at the paper. His dog sighed with the weight of someone who had attended a very long rehearsal.

“Fair,” Doug said. “It needs an ending.”

He played the beginning once more.

“And maybe a few more listeners.”

Chapter 2

Burgers and Big Plans

Doug moved his guitar aside so his friends could squeeze onto the porch steps.

"Play that bit again," one said.

Doug played the beginning.

"That needs a concert."

"It needs an ending first."

"You can finish it before supper."

Another friend leaned forward. "Is supper part of the concert?"

The screen door opened, and Mom stepped out.

"It can be," she said. "There's room for everyone."

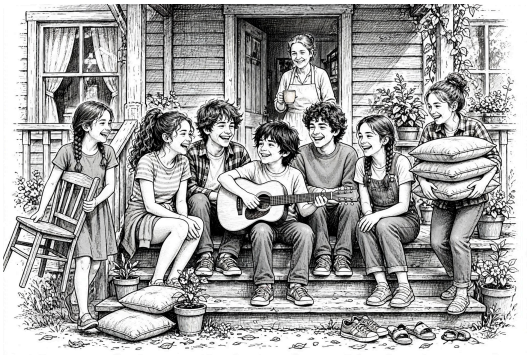
"Hamburgers?" Doug asked.

"And cheeseburgers."

That settled it. A song with no ending had become a concert with a menu.

His two sisters came out to inspect the porch. One carried a chair. The other carried two cushions and a look that meant she had already thought of something everyone else had missed.

“Leave a path to the door,” she said. “Unless you want supper delivered over your heads.”



Doug stood and raised a hand in a solemn greeting.

“Live long and prosper.”

“And pass the ketchup,” a friend added.

Soon they were planning a feast fit for a starship. There would be hamburgers, cheeseburgers, extra cheese, and enough pickles to supply a very small planet.

“Perhaps we should count people before planets,” Mom suggested.

She brought out cool water while they worked. When one friend hesitated by the steps, she handed over a cup.

“You’re staying too, I hope.”

The friend grinned and joined the chair-moving crew.

Doug studied the growing row of seats.

One sister pointed at an empty corner. “Chair here or there?”

He borrowed his best serious Bruce Lee voice.

“Don’t think. Feel.”

She felt the chair leg wobble.

"I feel this one needs a different spot."

Doug laughed and helped her move it.

At last he sat down and looked at all those places waiting for people he loved.

The concert looked bigger now.

Unfortunately, his song was still exactly the same size.

Chapter 3

Turn Up the Woods

Doug brushed his fingers across the guitar strings, trying to make the sound of leaves.

He tried again.

“That sounds like somebody sweeping the porch,” he said.

He picked the low notes faster. Now the motorcycle part sounded as if it were chasing the bird part.

Doug laid the guitar in its case.

“I’d better go listen.”

Soon, helmet fastened, he was riding back into the woods. The trail curved between the trees, and the engine settled into its familiar, happy rumble.

At the clearing, he stopped and switched it off.

A bird called.

Leaves rustled.

Then nothing much happened.

Doug waited.

There it was: room between the sounds. The woods weren’t trying to do everything at once.

He tapped his knee. Two slow beats. Two quick ones. A pause.

Back home, he picked up his guitar before the rhythm could slip away.

Low notes. Bright notes. A soft brush of strings.

And room to breathe.

Dad came onto the porch carrying a cable.

"Ready to try the speaker?"

Doug nodded.

His dad had spent years working professionally in sound. He could listen to a jumble and hear what needed fixing.

They connected the equipment, and Doug began.

The guitar boomed. His first words disappeared beneath it.

Doug stopped. "The woods got enormous."

"And swallowed the singer," Dad said.

He adjusted the controls, then moved the microphone a little closer.

"Try singing at your comfortable level. We'll bring the guitar underneath."



Doug played and sang.

“The road runs out, but the day rolls on.”

This time, every word reached the steps. The low rhythm rolled beneath his voice without rolling over it.

Doug grinned.

Dad listened from the farthest chair.

“That’s it. Don’t make people hunt for the words.”

Doug played through to the unfinished bit and stopped.

Dad raised an eyebrow.

“Now that’s a very roomy pause.”

Chapter 4

The Unexpected Solo

Doug tucked his guitar into its case and stretched his fingers.

One of his friends sat beside him on the porch steps. She slid her feet over to make room for his dog, who settled between them.

"Does he come to every rehearsal?" she asked.

"Every one. Never buys a ticket."

The dog leaned against Doug's leg.

"See? He knows somebody in the band."

They were still smiling when the dog stood up, made an unexpected gulping noise, and threw up beside the step.

Both friends sprang to their feet.

Doug's hand flew out. His friend caught his elbow. For a moment, they stood there holding each other upright, although neither had actually fallen.

Then Doug crouched beside his dog.

"Hey, partner. You all right?"

Mom came out at his call. She helped move the dog to a clean, quiet patch nearby and brought what they needed to tidy up.

“Let’s give him a little space,” she said gently.

Doug fetched paper towels. His friend held the bag. Mom stayed close to keep an eye on the dog, who soon lay down beside Doug’s shoes again.

Only then did Doug glance at his friend.

“You caught me.”



“You caught me first.”

“I wasn’t going anywhere.”

“Neither was I!”

A small giggle escaped her. Doug tried to answer, but his own giggle got in the way. Soon they were laughing at their magnificent rescue of two perfectly upright people.

Mom shook her head, smiling.

“Well. Excellent teamwork.”

Doug looked down at his faithful partner in crime. Then he looked at his friend, still wiping laughter from her eyes.

The missing ending began to stir.

His song didn’t need a grand finish deep in the woods. It could come home—to his people, his porch, and the surprises nobody could rehearse.

“Pass me that pencil,” he said. “Before anything else joins the band.”

Chapter 5

Hold That Thought

Doug laid his finished lyric sheets beside the microphone.

A gust lifted the top page.

He reached for it.

The second page sailed past his hand, and the third slid across the porch as if it had somewhere important to be.

“Hold that thought,” Doug said.

One sister caught a sheet against her knee. The other hurried after the page heading for the steps.

“I’ve got the beginning!”

“I’m chasing the middle!”



Doug started to follow, then paused. It was time for his usual diabetes care.

"I need a few minutes," he said.

"We've got the paper," his sister told him.

He stepped inside and took the time he needed. The concert could wait. Outside, he heard a triumphant "Got it!" followed by, "No, that's the back."

When Doug returned, both sisters were at the porch table, putting his song in order.

Dad steadied the microphone stand and shifted it away from the edge. With the calm hands of someone who had spent years setting up sound, he checked the speaker and tucked a loose cable out of the walking path.

"The sound's staying put," he said.

Doug rested his palm on the lyrics.

The paper fluttered beneath his fingers.

He looked at the sheets. Then he went to fetch a small board and some clips.

His sisters watched him lay the pages across the board. He clipped the top corners, tested the bottom edge, and added another clip.

No announcement. Just a little adjusting until it worked.

He propped the board where he could read it.

The breeze came nosing through again.

One corner trembled, but the song stayed put.

His sister folded her arms.

“Try chasing that.”

Doug gave the bottom clip one last squeeze.

“Please don’t challenge the weather.”

From the chairs came a laugh—and then the scrape of everyone settling in.

Chapter 6

One More, Doug

Doug settled the guitar against his knee and swept one hand toward the crowded porch.

"It's a madhouse! A madhouse!" he declared, borrowing his grandest Planet of the Apes voice.

A friend held up a cheeseburger.

"A well-fed madhouse."

Doug grinned. Around the porch, his friends balanced hamburgers and cheeseburgers on their plates. His family had found seats among them. Somebody passed the pickles without being asked.

"This one started in the woods," Doug said.

Then he played.

The low notes rolled along like an engine on a winding trail. Two bright notes answered them. His fingers brushed the strings, and leaves seemed to whisper through the spaces.

"The road runs out, but the day rolls on."

The talking quieted.

Doug looked up from the clipped pages. His friends were listening. Not waiting for their turn to speak. Listening.

He sang about bends in the trail and light between the branches. He let the little pauses stay.

Then came the ending.

"I went to find adventure where the tall trees touch the sky. I brought a pocketful of tunes and half the forest riding by."

His friend on the steps leaned forward.

"But home was full of people who had saved a place for me—and I'd sing another verse, except I smell the melted cheese."

For one beat, everyone was still.

Then the porch burst into laughter and cheers.

Doug's sisters clapped above their heads. Dad smiled from his chair. Mom lifted a plate with a cheeseburger waiting on it.

"One more, Doug!" somebody called.



The clapping gathered into a rhythm.

Clap-clap. Pause. Clap.

Doug tapped it softly against the guitar. There might be something in that. Something for tomorrow.

Tonight, his song had an ending, and his audience wanted another beginning.

"Absolutely," he said, reaching for his plate. "After this very important intermission."

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

RambleBook makes storybooks about the people you love, from the details only you know.

A storybook to keep & share

Doug is 16 years old. A keepsake storybook about Doug, made for Doug to keep, to show, and to read aloud.